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CHARTER GUIDE

Dolphin Watching by Boat in Marbella

Where, when and how: species, seasons, success rates and ethical viewing between Marbella and the Strait of Gibraltar.

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Why Marbella Is Dolphin Country

The waters between Marbella and the Strait of Gibraltar are some of the most dolphin-dense in the entire Mediterranean. Common, bottlenose and striped dolphins all live here year-round, and pilot whales pass through seasonally. A 4-hour charter heading offshore has roughly an 80% chance of meeting a pod, climbing to 90%+ in late spring and autumn when food fish are abundant.

This guide covers what you will see, how to do it ethically, and a practical itinerary for a dolphin-focused day on the water.

The Species You Will See

- ✦ **Common dolphin** (*Delphinus delphis*): small (1.5-2.5 m), yellow flank, large pods of 20-100+. The most frequently sighted species on a Marbella charter.
- ✦ **Bottlenose dolphin** (*Tursiops truncatus*): bigger (2.5-3.5 m), grey-blue, smaller pods of 5-20. The classic dolphin look. Resident populations live near the coast year-round.
- ✦ **Striped dolphin** (*Stenella coeruleoalba*): high-energy, lots of acrobatic leaping. Usually offshore over deeper water.
- ✦ **Pilot whale** (*Globicephala melas*): actually a large dolphin. Black, blunt head, slow surface behaviour. Pods of 10-30 pass through the Strait spring and autumn.
- ✦ **Occasional:** Risso's dolphin, fin whale (passage migrants), orca (rare, Strait of Gibraltar only).

Where to Find Them

The productive zone is 2-8 NM offshore from Marbella, especially the deeper water south-west towards the Strait. Bottlenose pods often patrol just outside the 2 NM coastal band you can reach on a licence-free boat, so a skippered charter is the practical option.

Heading west towards Sotogrande and Estepona puts you closer to the Strait current edges where common and striped dolphins feed on anchovy schools.

An Itinerary for a Dolphin-Focused Day

1. **08:00** Depart Puerto Banús. An early start improves your odds, with less boat traffic and a calmer sea.

2. **08:45** Reach the offshore zone, where the skipper slows to scanning speed (5-7 knots) and watches for surface activity, birds and gannet plunge-dives.
3. **09:30** First pod sighting. The boat shifts to parallel cruising at 60m distance, engine in neutral when fish-bait stops the pod.
4. **10:30-11:30** Multiple encounters possible. Bottlenoses often follow the boat for 15-30 minutes.
5. **11:30** Move inshore to anchor at Río Verde for a swim break.
6. **13:30** Cruise back to Puerto Banús, arriving by 14:00.

This works as a 6-hour charter on any motor yacht 12 m or above; see [yacht charter Marbella](#). Catamarans also work and offer slightly higher vantage from the trampolines; see [catamaran rental Marbella](#).



— A motor yacht of 12 m or above suits the six-hour dolphin itinerary

SECTION 05

Ethical Viewing Rules

Spanish marine regulations are clear and enforced:

- ♦ **60 metres minimum distance** from any cetacean.
- ♦ **Parallel approach only**, never head-on or from behind.
- ♦ **No surrounding** the pod; only one boat in the immediate area at a time.
- ♦ **No feeding, no touching**; both illegal and harmful.
- ♦ **Engine in neutral** if a pod approaches and stays. Let them set the pace.
- ♦ **Maximum 30 minutes** in the immediate vicinity of a single pod.

Operators that promise close approaches or guaranteed encounters are breaking the rules. Reputable Marbella skippers refuse and call out boats that violate.

Marbella or Further West

If wildlife is the sole goal, dedicated cetacean tours run from harbours further west on the Strait, with Tarifa and Algeciras the usual bases. From Marbella you get the better deal in our view: a full coastal charter (cruise + swim + dolphin sightings) on a yacht or catamaran of your choice, with departures from Puerto Banús, Marbella Marina, Cabopino or Sotogrande, and no early-morning long drive required.

Compare boat types for a dolphin day on the [boat rental Marbella](#) hub, or send a WhatsApp message with your dates for specific boats and skippers known for finding pods.



— Catamaran trampolines give a slightly higher vantage when scanning for fins

What to Bring, and Common Questions

Pack polarised sunglasses (they reduce surface glare for spotting fins), small binoculars (8x32), a phone or camera with image stabilisation, a windproof jacket for the 5-7 knot scanning run (it feels cool), and patience. Sometimes you find a pod in 20 minutes, sometimes in 90.

Are dolphin sightings guaranteed? Nothing in the wild is guaranteed, but the Strait of Gibraltar has some of the densest dolphin populations in the Mediterranean. A 4-hour charter heading offshore from Marbella has roughly an 80% sighting rate year-round.

How close will we get? Spanish marine regulations require boats to maintain at least 60 metres from cetaceans, approach parallel and never surround pods. Curious dolphins frequently approach the boat themselves and ride the bow wave; that is allowed when they choose to come to you.

What is the best month? April-June and September-October. The water is rich with anchovy and sardine schools, which the dolphins follow. July-August sightings still happen but warmer water disperses the fish and the pods are harder to find.

Can I swim with dolphins? No. Spanish marine law prohibits swimming with cetaceans, and reputable Marbella charters strictly follow this. Wild dolphins are observed from the boat at a respectful distance.

What is the minimum trip length? Four hours minimum gives you decent odds (offshore run + scanning time + return). Two-hour coastal cruises rarely encounter dolphins because the pods feed in deeper water 2-8 NM offshore.

Plan Your Dolphin Day

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